In the field, our orders for India games were simple: go and destroy them, almost like a suicide bomber does (I know that doesn't sound politically correct – at all – and *nobody ever gave that direct order*, so spare me and forgive me, but you know what I mean by that analogy!). Let nothing remain unresolved, untried or undecided.

Given the difficult political context of the times we live in, this sort of approach may sound controversial. But what I'm trying to say is that we had a give-it-all and take-no-prisoners approach to playing India. There was no ambiguity about the importance of the match, especially when we were playing them in India. Aware of the mission, be it a big match or a regular one against them, we didn't look back, nor did we care. So, sledging worked. So did aggressive body language. So did the passion of our youth. We used to take on everyone, pick a fight – a *panga* – with anyone who got in the way. The idea was not to be scared of anyone, be it a big star or an up-and-coming rookie. The mission was to take them all down not just with the cricket, but even with our body language and competitive aggression in tactics and talking. Honestly, that's how we used to take care of them, and till Indian cricketing standards really started to rise, as they have recently, our approach worked.

I've tried to study and understand the Indian team more than any other outfit out there. In the very early days of my career, Sachin Tendulkar was the only man in that unit who looked like a proper batsman. Then emerged Dravid, then Ganguly, and then came a flood of these new guys. However, all of them were groomed and polished over time, with experience.

But Sachin – he was always polished. I think he was born polished. He had his own style, grandeur and class. Eventually, Virender Sehwag and the likes joined him up there in terms of averages, but in those early days, we really used to take them all to town with our trademark positive aggression.

Before the balance of wins versus losses against India started to recently tip in India's favour due to Pakistan cricket's internal political and financial problems, till the time we retained a dominant position over them through the 1990s and well into the 2000s, our strategy was just in our heads – it was as if we knew that we would win. There was no other way to deal with India except mentally conditioning yourself for victory.

The attitude came easily and, no, we didn't have to be 'coached' into beating India. Since we were kids, the whole India versus Pakistan thing had possessed us, all of us. Even if the seniors didn't prep us with tactics for winning, we knew exactly how to defeat India on the field. The instinct to battle India was something we had internalized on our own.

Compared to other teams, I felt different when I played India. I still do. After all, it's not just a match. It's *the* match. Of course, the expectations from our team's fans, our families, our friends, are also different, much higher when playing India. It's not an exaggeration by any means when people say that India versus Pakistan is the sort of match that even those who don't know cricket are compelled to watch. Against India, it's not just a game. It's history in the making. It's the history of our people and our countries, written not in books but on the scoreboard, always to be remembered.

I can't say if I was particularly fond of 'targeting' any one Indian opponent on the field. But, to reiterate, the aggressive 'body language formula' was applied wholeheartedly and widely when it came to facing off against India. When you took the field to play India, you didn't just play eleven Indians. You played against the over a billion-people strong country itself, the thousands in the